

Fossils Show an Early Human Relative Lived in Africa Very Long Ago

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Scientists have studied new **fossils** from a cave in South Africa. They say an early human **relative** called Homo erectus lived there about 2 million years ago. That is about 200,000 years earlier than many scientists used to think.

Homo erectus belongs to the same group as modern humans, called Homo. It is probably one of our direct **ancestors**.

The **fossils** come from a cave called Drimolen, in an area known as the Cradle of Humankind. Many **fossils** from the cave had never been studied closely. A team led by La Trobe University in Australia looked at 18 of them.

One fossil is part of an adult Homo erectus **skull**. Before, scientists only had a child's **skull** from this cave.

Another **relative**, Paranthropus robustus, lived there too. It grew bigger teeth for crushing tough food. Lead researcher Jesse Martin said this **relative** once outnumbered Homo erectus by more than 10 to one!

Word Treasure

fossils -- Remains of living things from long ago, saved in rock.

ancestors -- Relatives who lived long, long before us.

skull -- The bones of the head.

relative -- A living thing that is part of the same family or group.

Background you need

Fossils help scientists learn what living things were like millions of years ago.

Several early human relatives lived in Africa long before modern people, and scientists study their bones to learn how humans changed over time.

Break it down

WHO: Scientists led by La Trobe University in Australia

WHAT: They studied 18 fossils, including part of an adult *Homo erectus* skull

WHERE: Drimolen cave in the Cradle of Humankind, South Africa

WHY: To learn when *Homo erectus*, a likely human ancestor, first lived in southern Africa

Why it matters

Fossils like these help answer a big question kids often ask: where did people come from?

Test what you remember

1. Where were the fossils found?

- ☐ (A) A desert in Egypt
- ☐ (B) A mountain in China
- ☐ (C) A cave in South Africa
- ☐ (D) A beach in Australia

2. About how long ago did *Homo erectus* live there?

- ☐ (A) About 200 years ago
- ☐ (B) About 2 million years ago
- ☐ (C) Last century
- ☐ (D) About 2,000 years ago

3. How many fossils did the team study?

- ☐ (A) 1,000
- ☐ (B) 18
- ☐ (C) 3
- ☐ (D) 100

4. What important new fossil was found?

- ☐ (A) Part of an adult *Homo erectus* skull
- ☐ (B) A stone tool
- ☐ (C) A dinosaur egg
- ☐ (D) A whole skeleton

5. What did *Paranthropus robustus* grow for crushing tough food?

- ☐ (A) Bigger teeth
- ☐ (B) Longer arms
- ☐ (C) Sharper claws
- ☐ (D) A bigger brain

6. Which relative was more common in the cave?

- ☐ (A) Modern humans
- ☐ (B) Monkeys
- ☐ (C) *Paranthropus robustus*
- ☐ (D) *Homo erectus*

Answer key (try the quiz first!): 1: C 2: B 3: B 4: A 5: A 6: C

Questions to think about

1. Lead researcher Jesse Martin: Says *Paranthropus robustus* once outnumbered *Homo erectus* by more than 10 to one.

MY THOUGHTS (at least 20 words):